

# Juliette

E<sup>1</sup>

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
|   |   | 7 |   |   | 2 |   |   |
|   | 3 |   | 4 |   |   | 2 |   |
| 8 |   |   |   |   |   |   | 1 |
|   | 4 |   | 1 |   | 6 | 7 |   |
|   |   |   |   | 4 |   |   |   |
|   | 9 |   | 2 |   | 3 |   | 5 |
| 7 |   |   |   |   |   |   | 9 |
|   | 6 |   | 8 |   | 9 |   | 3 |
|   |   | 4 |   |   | 8 |   |   |

E<sup>2</sup>

$$X = U(r)\Psi(r, \theta, \phi) = E(\Psi(r, \theta, \phi))$$

$$X = Y + Z$$

note: (use  $\pm$  pv as constant)

where:

$$Z = KK/LD$$

$$Z = PV$$

$$X6 + Z$$

where Z indicates Y

E<sup>4</sup>



$$L = Q(EG)U(CG)$$

$$M = Q$$

$$N = (QL)U(RT)$$

$$T = R(EG)U(FG)$$

$$R = T - (EG)$$

$$L \neq T$$

$$R \neq M$$

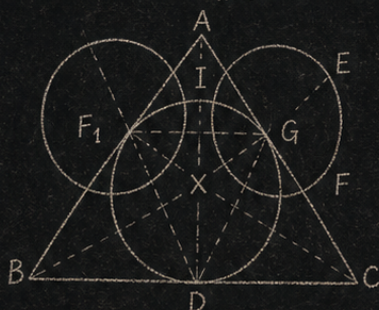
E<sup>3</sup>

$$Y = X(22)$$

$$S = Y(6) + Y(7)$$

$$Y^2 = X(23)$$

$$S^2 = Y(8) + Y(9)$$



Suppose  $x_4$  as solution

E<sup>5</sup>



$$X_6 = \frac{h^2}{2u} - \frac{1}{r^2 \sin \theta}$$

$$\left[ \sin \theta \frac{\partial}{\partial \psi} \right] + \frac{\partial}{\partial \theta}$$

$$\left( \sin \theta \frac{\partial^2}{\partial \theta^2} + \frac{1}{v^2} \frac{\partial^2}{\partial \psi^2} \right)$$

$$+ U(r) \Psi(r, \theta, \phi) \sin \theta \frac{\partial}{\partial \phi^2}$$

E<sup>6</sup>

$$X \sin E^2$$

$$X^3 2q(26) E^2$$

$$X^4 = (X^3 - 3) + \frac{\sqrt{13} + 17 + 16}{21 + 2q} + X^3 + 1(9)$$

DANIEL DU KINQUE

## **Author's note**

This is a novel-shaped draft built from memory, messages, and photographs. It does not treat every message as literal truth. It treats the record the way a mind treats love after it has ended: as evidence, as accusation, as shrine, as maze.

Where Juliette told me something terrible about her family, the story keeps it as a disclosure, not as a verified fact. Where I misunderstood her, the story leaves room for that. Where the archive makes me look obsessive, cruel, frightened, theatrical, or lost, it does not rescue me from myself.

The center of the book is not the archive. The center is a girl who became a problem I could not stop trying to solve.

That sentence is also the book's warning against itself. A person is not redeemed by becoming legible to the narrator. Juliette may leave this manuscript still contradictory, still unfair, still harmed, still harmful, still beautiful, still opaque. If the book succeeds, it does not solve her. It teaches the solving mind to stop calling possession by the name of care.

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# Part I: Chateau Model

## 1. The first photographs

The earliest photographs do not look like the beginning of a tragedy. They look like a performance after midnight: a blonde girl bent into a pose on a chair, black lingerie, fishnets, a pale little dog at her feet, the whole scene lit with the exhausted warmth of an apartment after a party. She looks young, theatrical, self-aware. She is playing at danger, or advertising it, or hiding inside it.

I met her in the summer of 2015 at our Eclair Fetish Ball. She was a Chateau model then, one of those girls who seemed to arrive already styled by rumor. In memory, she is not walking into a room so much as being noticed by it. Blonde, small, volatile, with the face of someone who had learned early that beauty could be armor, currency, disguise, invitation, and threat.

The Chateau world encouraged mythology. Everyone had names, roles, costumes, arrangements, contracts, secrets. It was easy to mistake performance for honesty because performance was often the only honest thing anyone had. Juliette fit that world perfectly and badly. She could be doll-like, bratty, sharp, obedient, wild, scared, calculating, wounded, playful. She seemed to understand being looked at, and she seemed to resent being seen.

That was the first trap.

To look at someone is easy. To see them is an obligation. With Juliette, I was never sure which one I was doing.

The October photographs show her among other models, dressed in costume, in a group of girls who look like they belong to a fantasy boutique: black and white outfits, bodies angled toward cameras, the familiar commerce of erotic subculture. In one image she is part of the crowd. In

another she is alone in a doorway. The group photographs are almost cheerful. They do not yet know what they will become in my mind.

I would later go back to those images looking for the first warning. I never found it. The warning was probably me.

## **2. New Orleans**

She came to New Orleans and we went on a date.

Even the word date was unstable between us. She later teased me about it, said I had taken her out because I had been told to. A forced date, a pushed date. She gave me a hard time because teasing was one of her safer forms of intimacy. It let her accuse without quite accusing. It let her test whether I would defend myself or play along.

New Orleans suited her. It is a city built for girls like Juliette, or for men like me imagining girls like Juliette: balconies, heat, decadence, costumes, the sense that every room has a past and every past is still drunk somewhere nearby. She moved through that atmosphere as if it had been waiting for her.

At the Vampire Ball, the fantasy failed in the most literal way. She drank too much and passed out in the women's toilet. That is the part a romantic version of the story would omit: not the blonde model shimmering through New Orleans, but the girl collapsed in a bathroom at a ball named for immortality. The city could make everything look theatrical, even danger, even humiliation, even a body reaching its limit while everyone around it kept pretending the night was beautiful.

The date became one of those early relationship stories we returned to as proof that something had happened. It was not just an outing. It was a marker. Before New Orleans, she was a model in orbit. After New Orleans, she was part of my private weather.

We joked about dates, date dates, dinner dates, romantic overtones. But under the jokes was the question that never stopped rearranging itself: what

was she to me, and what did she want to become?

I was married. That fact does not sit politely in the background. It enters every room first. Isi was not an incidental obstacle. She was my wife, my loyalty, my home, my first promise, and later, in Juliette's language, the proof that there was no reason to think she was in the equation anywhere.

I wanted to make room for Juliette without admitting that every room already belonged to someone else.

### **3. The pink violin**

On November 12, 2015, I bought her a pink violin.

There are gifts that are really proposals, even when no one calls them that. The violin was not just an object. It was a version of her I wanted to believe in: disciplined, delicate, artistic, salvageable. Pink because she was girlish and theatrical. Violin because I wanted her to have something beautiful that required practice instead of damage.

I liked giving her symbols. That may have been part of the problem. A symbol does not ask what the person actually needs. It converts them into meaning and then hands the meaning back as love.

But I remember the tenderness of it. I remember wanting to give her something that sounded like a future. Not a collar, not a costume, not a command. A violin. An instrument. A thing that could make order out of tension.

She was always tension.

I imagine it now as an object too bright for the room it entered. A pink violin is almost ridiculous unless you are in love, and then it becomes exact. It belonged to the Juliette who might practice scales instead of vanishing into messages, the Juliette who might turn discipline into music, the Juliette whose hands could hold something fragile without turning the fragility into a test.

Gifts are dangerous because they reveal the giver. The violin said less about who she was than who I needed her to become. I wanted to believe there was an instrument inside her waiting to be tuned. I wanted to believe that if I put beauty in her hands, beauty would answer.

That is not how people work.

In the early messages, the relationship appears in flashes: hospital, phone trouble, school, family, money, modeling, the Chateau, jokes about powerball tickets and dates and whether she was strong enough to choose a life outside the one she had been given. The tone could shift in seconds. Play, demand, philosophy, seduction, accusation, concern.

I told myself I was offering escape. That is a dangerous story for a man to tell about a young woman.

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## Part II: The Family Story

### 4. What she told me

She told me her father had been sleeping with her since she was five.

That sentence is almost impossible to write without either making it too certain or too weak. At the time, I believed her, or believed enough of her to behave as if believing was the only moral option. Later, I had doubts. She had a penchant for lying. She could invent, exaggerate, distort, conceal. She could tell a story in such a way that the emotional truth arrived ahead of the facts and demanded shelter.

I do not know what happened to Juliette as a child. I know what she told me. I know what it did to me. I know that after she said it, every conversation about her family became charged with disgust, rescue, erotic confusion, and moral panic.

The archive is full of my certainty before I had earned certainty. I spoke of her parents as if I understood them. I spoke of her father as if the allegation itself made me judge, jury, savior, and rival. I used words like justice. I imagined confrontation. I imagined extraction. I imagined myself stronger than her family.

There is a particular arrogance in wanting to rescue someone whose truth you do not fully know. It feels noble from the inside. From the outside, it can look like possession wearing armor.

Juliette's family was not just background. They were gravity. School, money, phone, apartment, parents, mother, father: these were not ordinary topics. They were the walls of her life. She often seemed to push against them and defend them in the same breath. She wanted out. She wanted approval. She wanted secrecy. She wanted to be believed. She wanted not to be known.

I wanted a clean story: wounded girl, monstrous father, heroic escape.

Juliette never gave me clean stories.

## 5. February

I visited her in February 2016.

By then everything had the feel of a crisis already underway. Her parents tracked her down. We ended up in a high-speed chase, or what memory has preserved as one: motion, panic, the knowledge that the phone could betray her location, the sense that the ordinary world had suddenly accepted the logic of a thriller.

Before the chase, there was Columbus at night. She drank too much at a bar and disappeared into the ordinary machinery of emergency: ambulance, hospital, fluorescent light. I picked her up afterward. Later, when we tried to summarize the trip, the sequence came out almost absurdly compressed: I came to visit; she drank herself into the hospital; there was sex; then rupture. In another message I remembered watching her being taken away in an ambulance, as if the scene had fixed itself more securely than whatever explanation came after it.

That was one of the patterns with Juliette. Disaster did not arrive once. It arrived in installments, each one asking to be treated as exception. A bathroom floor in New Orleans. An ambulance in Columbus. A hospital pickup. A girl embarrassed, intoxicated, unreachable, then suddenly tender or sexual or gone.

The strange thing about crisis is how much waiting it contains. You wait outside bathrooms. You wait in hospital corridors. You wait in cars. You wait for phones to turn back on, for nurses to release someone, for parents to stop calling, for adrenaline to decide what kind of memory it wants to become. You wait beside someone you love and discover that love does not give you jurisdiction.

When I picked her up from the hospital, I was not angry in the clean way anger likes to remember itself. I was frightened, aroused by rescue, ashamed



of the arousal, relieved she was alive, irritated that this had become my role, proud that I was the one who came, and already converting the scene into proof that I mattered. I could tell myself I was taking care of her. I was. I could also tell myself that taking care of her gave me a claim. That part was uglier.

Her father threatened me with a hammer and a gun. Police came.

This is the scene the book must approach carefully, because it is too easy to write it as melodrama and too dishonest to soften it into confusion. It happened in the terrible zone where family, law, sexuality, and rescue fantasies overlap. A man with a hammer. A gun. A daughter caught between worlds. Police as witnesses, not solutions. Me standing there with all my theories about justice and none of the power I imagined I had.

Afterward, I did not hear from her for a while.

That silence became its own room. I walked around inside it asking the same questions in different forms. Had they taken her phone? Had she chosen them? Had I made everything worse? Had she lied? Had I believed too much? Had I believed too little? Was she safe? Was she punishing me? Was she free?

What I wanted was a direct sentence.

Juliette sent an equation.

## **6. The puzzle**

On February 23, 2016, she transformed the end into a puzzle.

She said she would write me an equation and that by the time I figured it out I would know why I had been blocked from her life completely. I said I liked equations. It is embarrassing how eager I was to accept the form of my own dismissal. She had given me a task, and a task was better than abandonment.

She had an Apple appointment. She was picking up food. She said she had little prior information to include because it was not a test. She said the problem was clear, solvable, complete. Nothing additional needed defining.

Then the image: Sudoku, algebra, geometry, set notation, physics, the boxed instruction: suppose  $x4$  as solution.

I understood the emotional grammar before the mathematics. The page was crowded with systems. Every region had rules. Every symbol belonged somewhere. The paper looked like a mind trying to make pain objective. She had refused to tell me plainly what I had done. Instead she built a machine that converted a wrong choice into inevitability.

When I solved it, she said I had done it quickly. She would have made it harder if she had had more time.

That is Juliette condensed into one gesture: punishment, wit, intelligence, performance, cruelty, charm, and an almost childlike pride in the construction.

The puzzle let her remain superior to the pain. If she simply told me what I had done, she would have had to stand inside the accusation with me. Instead she made a system. Systems do not cry. Systems do not admit longing. Systems can be solved or failed, and either result preserves the authority of the person who built them.

I think she wanted me to understand and wanted me not to. If I failed, I had proved the distance between us. If I solved it, I had proved that the distance was chosen, not accidental. Either way, she could leave.

I remember feeling a kind of gratitude. That is the embarrassing part. She had blocked me, condemned me, hidden the charge, and still I was grateful because she had made the ending intimate. A normal goodbye would have belonged to the world. The equation belonged to us.

I kept the equation in my head long after the relationship moved on. Later, when she said she had no reason to think she was in the equation anywhere, she was no longer talking about the puzzle. She was talking

about us. She had taken the metaphor back from the paper and placed it into the relationship itself.

The equation was never solved. It only changed variables.

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## Part III: Return by Image

### 7. Screenshots after silence

The photographs resume before the relationship fully does.

March 2016: a screenshot of her Facebook profile. Another screenshot of a message. These are not portraits exactly. They are artifacts of distance, proof that I was looking through interfaces to find her. The images from April are more direct: a blonde selfie, then two similar images where she looks pale, made-up, almost doll-like. She is framed by her phone and by my attention.

May becomes intimate and strange. There are images from messages, selfies, FaceTime screenshots. She is in low light, on a couch, holding a candle or a glass, eating something, looking bored or tired or amused. Some frames are inverted, accidental, bodily, uncomposed. They feel less like photographs meant for memory than fragments shed by a conversation too constant to remain verbal.

The images say what the messages also say: we were not done.

She re-entered not as the girl of the February chase but as a mediated presence: blue light, screen glow, late-night calls, poses, jokes, need. Her face appears in a little FaceTime box beside mine. Sometimes she looks like a child up too late. Sometimes like a woman performing indifference. Sometimes like someone who has survived by splitting herself into versions and sending whichever one the moment requires.

By late May, the photo record is thick with recurrence. She is there again and again, not as event but as atmosphere.

I can see now how hungry I was for proof. A photograph says: she existed here. A screenshot says: this happened. A FaceTime still says: we were both awake at the same time and looking at one another. None of it says what any of it meant.

There is a particular loneliness to loving someone through screenshots. You do not have the person. You have evidence of access. A blue bubble. A cropped face. A profile page. A timestamp. The little interface decorations become emotional architecture: delivered, read, typing, missed call, image saved. The phone teaches you to mistake signals for presence.

Juliette was good at appearing. She could send an image that made me feel chosen and disappear before I could ask what the choosing meant. She could make a selfie feel like confession. She could make a FaceTime frame feel like a visit. The more mediated the relationship became, the more I treated each artifact as if it might contain the whole person if I stared long enough.

## **8. June: together again**

The June photographs are different. We are in the same physical world.

June 26: she sits across a room, blonde hair, small body, casual clothes, a man nearby. Then images in a car, my face in the foreground, her beside me. Then in a park, sitting on grass under trees. Then the next day, close together in dim light, our faces pressed into the frame.

These are relationship photographs. Not clean ones, not ordinary boyfriend-girlfriend images, but still: two people sharing space, travel, fatigue, food, weather, closeness. They have the ordinary ugliness of real life, which makes them more tender than the staged images. They are not Chateau. They are not equation. They are not courtroom or chase. They are car seats, lawns, bad angles, the accidental intimacy of being somewhere together.

The local iMessages begin at the end of June, after this return has already happened. The first lines are almost mundane: How's life. Spelunking. How's you. No phone, no car. Buses, Charleston, Myrtle Beach, parties, dates, pretty people, whether to bring someone, whether she is going with someone else.

It is shocking, after everything, how quickly catastrophe becomes logistics.

We talked as if we could still arrange the world. Buses, beaches, cocktails, parties. Want company? Want to accompany me? Bring someone pretty. Z is annoying me. Everyone annoys me. The ordinary flirtation of two people who have already done too much damage to be ordinary.

The relationship in July is restless, erotic, jealous, playful, unstable. We are negotiating roles without admitting they are negotiations. I want access. She wants freedom and attention. I am married. She is entangled with other men, other plans, other states. Every invitation has a rival inside it.

I still thought there might be a structure that could hold us.

The pictures from June are almost gentle because they are so badly composed. In one, I am too close to the camera and she is beside me in the car, tired and blonde and holding herself inside the frame. In another she sits in grass at a park, half turned away, the day too ordinary for myth. In the late-night images our faces crowd together in darkness, not beautiful so much as present.

Presence was rare enough to become sacred.

When she was in front of me, the theories quieted. Not vanished, but quieted. Her body simplified the problem. She needed food, sleep, attention, a ride, a joke, a place to sit. I could do those things. I was better with concrete tasks than with moral ambiguity. Give me a hospital pickup, a car, a hotel, a meal, a girl in a passenger seat, and I could perform devotion. Ask me where she belonged in my life, and I started writing equations.

## 9. Surveillance

By September, surveillance had become erotic language.

We were talking about Facebook tracking and how little people cared. Juliette said she was all for surveillance. Anyone could exploit it, she said,

so it was freedom. I told her I would watch her. She said I would be bored.

I told her I had fantasies about secret cameras in her bedroom.

There is no way to make that line innocent. The manuscript should not try. It belongs to the atmosphere of the relationship: fascination without enough boundary, concern braided with voyeurism, desire disguising itself as study. Juliette replied that she was hardly ever at her apartment. She had a roommate. Then the conversation moved toward her father's house, toward video, toward instructions, toward the same family darkness that always returned.

The camera thread matters because it shows how the relationship metabolized danger. What should have been horror became erotic grammar. What should have remained private became something I wanted to witness. What I called fascination was sometimes a refusal to let her remain opaque.

She was all for surveillance, she said.

I was all for watching.

Neither of us sounded free.

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## Part IV: October

### 10. The flood

October 2016 is where the archive becomes a weather system.

There are more than twelve thousand message records from that month alone. The relationship no longer moves in episodes. It pours. We talk about parties, rooms, parents, boyfriends, wives, sex, loyalty, New Orleans, vampires, school, pageants, cars, apartments, food, fear, role models, families, guns, jealousy, devotion. Nothing stays in its lane.

Juliette is not simply a lover. She is confidante, rival, child, judge, fantasy, moral witness, legal counsel in jokes, daughter, girlfriend to someone else, would-be partner, girl trying to graduate, girl trying to party, girl trying to be good, girl trying not to be trapped. I am not simply a lover either. I am husband, Daddy, rescuer, manipulator, supplicant, accuser, caretaker, confessor, architect of impossible arrangements.

October is when she says the thing that revises the equation.

Without asking me? she says. I seem like an important component of the equation.

Five days later, she says it more plainly: You could be there for me, but haven't been. You're really only there for Isi at the end of the day. You have no idea how much I respect that. But I share that level of loyalty and I know there's no reason to think I'm in the equation anywhere.

This is the heart of the later relationship.

In February, x4 had been my wrong choice. In October, the equation was the system of my life. Isi was in it. Chateau was in it. New Orleans was in it. Other men were in it. Juliette was asking whether she appeared anywhere except as variable, exception, fantasy, emergency.



She respected my loyalty and was wounded by it. That was her intelligence. She did not simply want me to abandon my wife. She understood that the loyalty she loved in me was the same loyalty that excluded her. She wanted to be chosen by a man whose best quality, from her perspective, was that he did not easily choose someone else.

There is no clean solution to that. There is only arithmetic done on human beings.

October is exhausting to read because it has no respect for scale. A joke about food sits beside a threat. A sexual fantasy beside a legal plan. A pageant beside a breakdown. A household logistics problem beside a declaration of eternal love. We were not having conversations so much as generating weather: pressure systems, storms, sudden pockets of warmth.

By then Juliette had become one of the people I told everything to, which is different from being one of the people I protected. I gave her access to my distress and called it intimacy. She gave me judgment and called it honesty. We used each other as mirrors and then punished the mirror for reflecting too clearly.

The line about not being in the equation anywhere hurt because it was accurate in a way I did not want to concede. She was in my desire. She was in my imagination. She was in my emergency responses, my fantasies, my messages, my photographs, my plans for rooms. But was she in my life as a chosen structural fact? Or was she always the variable that had to adapt to everything already fixed?

That is what she knew before I did.

## **11. Role model**

By late October and early November, Juliette talked about role models.

She said she needed me as one. She said she had a weird thing about me and Isi as a model for staying together. She loved me and wanted me to be happy, and Isi made me happy. This was not the speech of a simple rival. It

was stranger and sadder. She wanted entry into the very structure that kept her outside.

She wanted to be loved by the marriage, or disciplined by it, or adopted into it, or judged by it. She wanted my attention and my wife's stability. She wanted my desire and my household's legitimacy. She wanted to be special without destroying the thing that made specialness valuable.

I did not know how to give that. I probably pretended I did.

The messages are full of rooms. Little girl room. Sexy room. Extra bedroom. Your room. Dining room. Secret rooms. Rooms become the domestic equivalent of variables: if we put this person here and that person there, can the system balance? If Isi sleeps there, if Juliette sleeps here, if another girl visits, if New Orleans happens, if Vampire is neutralized, if Sean understands, if parents do not interfere, if everyone accepts the right role.

The house becomes another equation.

No one solves it.

## **12. New Orleans again**

New Orleans returns in October like a recurring dream.

Juliette plans to go with Sean. Then not go. Then knows the address. Then does not want to pursue. Then says she is going to party. New Orleans, once the scene of our early date, becomes a contested territory: pleasure, jealousy, obligation, wife, boyfriend, Chateau, Vampire, danger.

She says there is nothing crazy about going to New Orleans with her boyfriend. She says she will not bother me with it. She says she is done. She says she is not pursuing. She says she is going to have fun.

I do not read those lines as indifference. I read them as a girl trying to stand somewhere that does not collapse beneath her.

In the same period, there are messages about guns in New Orleans, threats, fathers who want to kill me, bad parenting, family admiration, and ordinary preferences about baseball, cream cheese, and breakfast. The archive refuses genre. It will not stay thriller, romance, kink memoir, family tragedy, or comedy. It is all of them within minutes.

That may be the truest thing about the relationship. It had no stable genre.

The second New Orleans was not a place so much as a test neither of us admitted we were taking. If she went with Sean, did that prove she was free of me? If I went with Isi, did that prove she was excluded? If we all occupied the same city, could the city absorb the contradiction the way it absorbs everything else: sex, costume, betrayal, worship, bad decisions, dawn?

The city that had once made her shimmer now made everyone look implicated.

New Orleans is good at taking private disorder and giving it a balcony.

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## **Part V: Afterimages**

### **13. The objects left behind**

There are photographs after the main storm: a driver's license held in a hand in November 2016, screenshots in 2017, a portrait in a car. The late relationship images are quieter than the first ones. They do not announce themselves as symbols. They are simply what remained.

The archive gives the illusion of continuity. A girl becomes a woman in fragments. But that is not life. It is only what remained in one library under one name.

The pink violin remains because I remember it.

The equation remains because she made it impossible not to.

The photographs remain because faces are easier to preserve than explanations.

The messages remain because neither of us knew how to stop writing.

### **14. What I know about Juliette**

I know she was beautiful.

I know she was smarter than her chaos made her look. She liked puzzles, challenges, problems. She could compress accusation into symbolic form. She could move from flirtation to cruelty to vulnerability in a handful of messages. She could be very funny.

I know she told stories I could not verify.

I know she told me things that, if true, should have made everyone around her stop and protect her. I also know she sometimes lied, and that my desire to believe her was not pure. Belief gave me a role. Doubt would have required humility.

I know her family frightened and fascinated me. I know I turned that fascination into moral certainty too quickly.

I know she wanted to matter. Not just to be desired, not just to be watched, not just to be rescued, but to matter in the actual arithmetic of a life.

I know she understood loyalty. She respected it in me even when it hurt her. Maybe especially then.

I know I failed her in ways I can name and ways I probably still cannot.

I know she failed me too, but that is less interesting. Everyone fails the person who asks them to become an answer.

## **15. The unsolved thing**

If this is a novel, Juliette cannot be only a mystery. That would be another way of using her. She cannot be only a victim, because I do not know what happened. She cannot be only a liar, because lies often grow around real wounds. She cannot be only a lover, because much of what bound us was not love but intensity. She cannot be only an antagonist, because she was also a girl trying to survive herself.

She is the blonde model at the fetish ball.

She is the date in New Orleans.

She is the pink violin.

She is the daughter in the high-speed chase.

She is the girl who sends an equation instead of an explanation.

She is the woman in the FaceTime window, late at night, tired and luminous.

She is the voice saying she is not in the equation anywhere.

She is the later photograph, still looking straight at the camera as if she knows the camera will not know what to do with her.

The answer was supposed to be  $x^4$ .

But the real solution was never a variable. It was the recognition that no one can be solved without being reduced. I spent years trying to solve Juliette because solving looked like devotion from inside the maze. It was not. It was a way to keep her close without letting her be free of my interpretation.

The proper ending is not that I understand her.

The proper ending is that I stop pretending understanding is the price of love.

But stopping is not the same as erasing. I still have the images. I still have the equation. I still have the pink violin in memory, if not in sight. I still have New Orleans, Columbus, the ambulance, the hammer, the gun, the hospital light, the FaceTime glow, the car photographs, the park, the messages arriving faster than either of us could become wise.

If I write her now, I have to write myself as part of the danger. Not the only danger. Not the worst danger. But part of it. I wanted to save her, possess her, understand her, discipline her, display her, protect her, and be chosen by her. Those wants did not cancel each other. They braided into something I called love because love was the only word large enough to hide inside.

Juliette deserved better than being solved.

So did I.

## Epilogue: The Deputy

By 2021, Juliette was no longer a girl in a photograph, no longer the Chateau model at the edge of the summer, no longer the woman in New Orleans who drank too much and disappeared into the women's toilet at the Vampire Ball, no longer the young woman in Columbus whose family could find her by the phone in her pocket. She had become a voice in a file.

The call came on June 28, 2021.

It did not arrive as a letter, or a confession, or one of her strange proofs. It arrived through dispatch, non-emergency, and was passed to a deputy in El Paso County. In the report she is not Juliette. She is not Katelyn. She is X, a redacted initial where a person used to be.

That is the last transformation in the story.

When I met her, she was almost all image: the fetish ball, the model photographs, the violin, the fairy-tale danger of a girl who seemed to have stepped out of a darker room than the rest of us. She told me things I did not know how to verify. Some of them may have been true. Some of them may have been lies. Some may have been neither, exactly, but forms of survival: stories told because the truth was too plain, or too humiliating, or too impossible to say directly.

The deputy's report gives none of that music. It gives date, time, jurisdiction, call number, status. It says she called. It says she wished to remain anonymous. It says she asked to be contacted by telephone. It says the deputy called her at about 3:20 in the afternoon and spoke with her for sixty-three minutes.

Sixty-three minutes is a long time to reduce a life to a statement.

In that hour, she described The Chateau. She described a world presented as a modeling opportunity. She said she had been contacted around 2015 through social media, under the impression of a modeling

audition. She said she went to an event with a male associate, briefly met Daniel and Isi, and then felt the atmosphere change. The gathering became sexual. She became uncomfortable. She left.

That is the version that entered the record.

Not the violin. Not the equation. Not the hospital. Not the chase. Not the hammer, the gun, the police, the father, the things she said and the things I still cannot know. Not the messages where we tried to make philosophy out of desire, or puzzles out of silence. Not the way she could turn intimacy into a theorem and then vanish before I could check the work.

Just this: a woman calls a deputy six years later and tells him that the place she entered as a model was something else.

After the call, the deputy kept texting with her on his office phone. The report says her spoken statement and written text messages became part of the investigation. That small administrative fact feels like the final joke of the whole affair. All along, Juliette had been made of messages. Facebook messages, iMessages, photos, screenshots, riddles, fragments. In the end, even the state received her that way: a voice first, then text.

By October 23, 2021, the investigation was marked inactive. All investigative leads had ceased.

That sentence is colder than goodbye.

But it is also a kind of ending. Not an ending of love, because whatever this was had stopped being love long before. Not an ending of truth, because truth never arrived cleanly enough to stand alone. It is the ending of a signal. The last known Juliette is not the girl at the ball, or the girl with the pink violin, or the girl who sent an impossible equation from the other side of fear. The last known Juliette is a redacted caller in a case report, speaking for sixty-three minutes to a deputy, translating a private mythology into the language of suspicion.

Maybe that was always where the equation led.



Not to x, or y, or any solved variable, but to a blank initial in a police file. A person reduced to X. A relationship reduced to a statement. A story reduced to whether anyone, years later, still believed the first premise.

I do not know what happened to Juliette.

I know what she told me. I know what I doubted. I know what I wanted to believe. I know what I wrote back. I know that I bought her a pink violin because beauty seemed like something that could rescue a person if you placed it carefully enough in her hands.

It could not.

In the end, she made one more call. She gave one more version. Then the leads ceased.